Modi's New Swadeshi Deal
May 25, 2020

"When he began his address to the nation on May 12, Modi chose the occasion to present a soaring vision of India's ability to emerge as a strong, self-reliant nation. He talked money, announcing a financial stimulus package of Rs 20 lakh crore to revive India's Covid-stricken economy, terming the package the *Atmanirbhar Bharat Abhiyan*."





The Big FDI Blast
Jul. 4, 2016

"India had flung its doors open wider to foreign investment. Foreigners could now own airlines, set up food processing firms, defence manufacturing units and buy pharmaceutical companies. It was the most assiduous wooing of FDI in the 20 years since India had first looked to foreign exchange as a fuel to kickstart the engines of its economy."

Unlocking LIC
Mar. 22, 2017

"LIC is a financial behemoth like no other in the country. For years, successive Indian governments have treated it as family silver—a prized possession they considered sinful to part with. But desperate times call for desperate measures. The impending LIC IPO has now become critical to rescuing the government from the financial pickle it finds itself in."



CLOSE TO 270 MILLION PEOPLE HAVE BEEN LIFTED FROM EXTREME POVERTY IN INDIA, THE RATE DROPPING FROM 27% (2011-12) TO 5.3% (2022-23)

the hope that increased public spending would crowd in private investment.

The government did not stray from this path of *aatmanirbharta* even in the worst of times, as during COVID-19. It chose instead to ease credit lines to businesses and extend sectors under PLI rather than loosen its purse strings.

Ease of doing business began at the institutional level, when the 65-year-old Planning Commission was replaced with the NITI Aayog in 2015. Two years later came the revolutionary Goods and Services Tax, streamlining multiple indirect taxes under one structure. Consolidation, in fact, became a guiding mantra of the Modi years, particularly when it came to rescuing India's beleaguered banking system. The number of public sector banks was pared from 27 to 12 between 2017 and 2020 and the toxic legacy of NPAs addressed through a '4R' strategy: recognition, resolution, recapitalisation and reform.

Distressed corporates, too, got an exit route with the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code (IBC), which put in place a time-bound mechanism for corporate debt resolution. A further fillip for the corporates came in September 2019, when the headline tax rate was slashed from 30 per cent to 22 per cent.

The clean-up extended to the real estate sector, thriving on zero builder accountability, leaving millions of prospective home buyers in a lurch. The Real Estate (Regulation and Development) Act, 2016, mandated every state to set up a Real Estate Regulatory Authority (RERA), which would enforce transparency, fix accountability and be a formal avenue for dispute resolution.

And though disinvestment drew a mixed record overall, the needle did move on two public sector behemoths—Air India and LIC. The government managed to sell off the debt-laden national airlines to the Tatas in January 2022 and, four months later, sold a 3.5 per cent stake in LIC through its first-ever initial public offering.

Finally, as the decade drew to a close, India turned its attention to labour reform, conflating 29 laws into four codes: on wages, industrial relations, social security, and occupational safety, health and working conditions.

As of 2025, then, India had overtaken Japan to become the world's fourth largest economy and seemed on course to become the third largest by 2030. Its GDP growth remains among the best in the world's large economies. Multi-dimensional poverty, too, has come down from 27 per cent in 2011-2012 to 5.3 per cent in 2022-2023.

Yet, private investment lags, and inequality has grown. Agriculture reform has been a non-starter; generating jobs remains a persistent challenge, a lost opportunity for utilising the country's demographic dividend. And despite all the government's efforts at skilling, a majority of the country's graduates continue to be unemployable, darkening India's future. ■